



SIPRA DAS

DELHI | Soul Searching

L.K. Advani had to rise out of the doldrums of dejection where he had fallen following the Election 2009 results. His agenda was to try to settle a few rankling issues at the party's national executive last weekend. The BJP has been ridden with factional fighting, ideological confusion and is facing an existential crisis. With this in mind, Advani tried to take up the role of an arbitrator, a Bhishma Pitamah-like role hitherto reserved for the unparalleled Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Amid the ongoing struggle for leadership, Advani reasserted himself and sought to settle one of the most contentious issues in the party—Hindutva. He said that there was a similar debate in 1979-80 when the Janata Party split and the BJP was born. Quoting former RSS chief Balasaheb Deoras, Advani said that change and debate is essential for any political movement to grow. Seeking to define Hindutva, the party in its resolution claimed, "Theocracy or any form of bigotry is alien to our ethos. Hinduism, or Hindutva, is not to be understood or construed narrowly; nor is it confined only to religious practices or expressed in extreme forms. It is related to the culture and ethos of the people of India, depicting a way of life. It is inclusive, representing the finest imprints of our cultural and civilisational ideas." Showing the road ahead, there was no mention of Article 370, a uniform civil code or the Ayodhya temple. *by Bhavna Vij-Aurora*

ADVANI (LEFT)
WITH BJP
PRESIDENT
RAJNATH SINGH

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Lok Sabha seats is what the BJP won when it contested general elections for the first time in 1984. In the next polls in 1989, it got all of 86 seats.